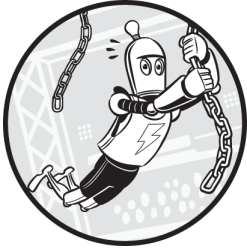


# INTRODUCTION



Hello again, world! As a teenage programmer and wannabe hacker in the late 1990s, I would pore over the latest issues of *2600: The Hacker Quarterly*.

One day, I finally summoned the courage to attend the magazine's monthly meetup in my city and was in awe of how knowledgeable everyone else seemed. (Later, I'd realize that many of them had more confidence than actual knowledge.) I spent the entire meeting nodding along to what others were saying, trying to keep up with their conversations. I left that meetup determined to spend every waking hour studying computing, programming, and network security so I could join the discussions at the next month's meetup.

At the next meetup, I continued to just nod and feel dumb compared to everyone else. So again I resolved to study and become "smart enough" to keep up. Month after month, I would increase my knowledge but always felt behind. I began to realize the enormity of the computing field and worried I would never know enough.

I knew more about programming than my high school friends but certainly not enough to get a job as a software developer. In the 1990s,